



Our Mission

Emma Zheng · Girl Scout Gold Award Project

Empowering Chinese-speaking immigrant families with early autism awareness, helping parents recognize early warning signs, and guiding them to accessible, high-quality local screening and intervention services.



Critical Brain Development Window

Ages 18–36 months represent the most decisive window for childhood neurodevelopment. Early screening and timely intervention significantly improve long-term outcomes for communication, social, and adaptive skills.

Project Footprint: Chinese-speaking families across the DMV area · Bilingual community education · Free downloadable resources

Autism is an innate neurodevelopmental difference, completely unrelated to parenting style or vaccines. Research consistently demonstrates that early identification and prompt support unlock a child's highest potential.

Early Signs & Red Flags

Core Milestones (Ages 12–36 Months)



Limited Eye Contact



No Pointing to Show



Delayed Speech



Repetitive Behaviors



No Pretend Play



Sensory Sensitivities

⚠️ "Golden Rule" (Any Age): Any regression or loss of speech, babbling, eye contact, gestures, or social skills at any age requires immediate evaluation by a pediatrician.



SOCIAL & PLAY MILESTONES

12 Months: Does not respond to name · Does not play interactive games (peek-a-boo)

15 Months: Does not bring or show toys to parents to share excitement

18–24 Months: Does not point to show interest · Does not imitate actions · No pretend play

Behavioral Patterns: Hand-flapping, rocking, spinning · Extreme distress at everyday sounds or lights

Joint Attention Delays: Does not point to direct an adult's attention or look when an adult points.



4 STEPS TO SEEK SUPPORT

- 1 Observe & Track:** Note specific red flags, track behaviors, and review milestones using validated checklists.
- 2 Talk to Your Pediatrician:** Request an M-CHAT-R/F screener at well-child visits; proactively share your observations.
- 3 Comprehensive Assessment:** Moderate or high risk prompts referral to developmental pediatrics or early intervention teams.
- 4 Start Early Intervention:** Contact local services (Fairfax ITC for ages 0–3, FCPS Child Find for ages 20 months–5 years). Screenings and evaluations are free, and services do NOT require an official diagnosis or SSN to begin (a suspected delay qualifies).



Multidimensional Spectrum Wheel

Autism is a broad spectrum where developmental domains (sensory, language, social, motor, executive) vary independently. Rather than a linear "mild to severe" scale, each child forms a unique profile shape, highlighting individual strengths while guiding tailored support.

Resources & Support

Learn · Support · Advance Awareness
Understanding · Action · Community



? MISCONCEPTIONS & CLINICAL FACTS

MYTH

"Children who can speak cannot have autism."

FACT

Autism is a broad spectrum. Many autistic children speak fluently but need support with social reciprocity, nonverbal cues, or sensory regulation.

MYTH

"The child is young; let us wait and see if they outgrow it."

FACT

Ages 18–36 months are the golden intervention window. Waiting delays critical support during the brain's most adaptable phase.

MYTH

"Autism is caused by cold parenting or vaccines."

FACT

Autism is an innate neurodevelopmental difference. Decades of clinical research definitively refute links to parenting styles or vaccines.



OFFICIAL & LOCAL US RESOURCES

- Fairfax CSB Entry Point (703-324-4400):** Primary county intake number for early intervention and support services. No SSN required.
- Infant & Toddler Connection (Fairfax ITC):** Early intervention for infants and toddlers (ages 0–3). Screenings are free; therapies use a sliding scale (no family turned away).
- Child Find (FCPS):** Free developmental screenings for children (ages 20 months to 5 years) in Fairfax County Public Schools.
- CDC "Learn the Signs. Act Early":** Free milestone checklists, symptom trackers, and developmental monitoring tools.
- Autism Speaks & 100-Day Kit:** Comprehensive family guides and toolkits translated into Chinese for newly diagnosed families.
- Autism Society of Northern Virginia (ASNV): (703) 537-9487** (Education programs, webinars, and local community support groups)



CONTACT & PRESENTATIONS

- Email: ezhengva@gmail.com
- Website: emmaz-sv.github.io/early-autism-awareness
- Free bilingual presentations available for schools, clinics, and community groups